A QUIET ARRANGEMENT
SECOND DRAFT

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# CHAPTER I — ARRIVAL HALL

Hong Kong still had the talent for making grief feel like an administrative error.

The cabin lights rose for descent and, with them, the old reflex returned: sit up straighter, smooth your face, become the version of yourself that doesn't inconvenience anyone. Grace had crossed oceans and time zones in a wide seat with a soft blanket and discreet service; none of it mattered. On the screen, the little plane inched towards Lantau, making dread look measurable.

She had not expected to be afraid of the quiet. In London, grief could be private. You could cry on a bus and strangers would stare past you as if you were weather. Hong Kong noticed, and noticing was the first step towards management. She had been away long enough to forget that she was trained.

Her mother's last call had been calm, already on rails. "They've said he's stable. The doctors are optimistic. It's good you're coming now. Temporary, Grace. We just need you here until things settle." Temporary had been tied on like ribbon. Grace had said yes because refusing would have required a conversation her mother had already decided.

She checked her phone one last time before switching to flight mode. A calendar reminder blinked for a dinner that

had been moved to "later" without asking, and an unread email from a lecturer sat beneath it, polite and useless: We'll discuss your extension when things stabilise. Her mother's text was at the top, unadorned and final: Car ready. Straight to hospital. Don't worry. Grace stared until the words stopped being words and became instruction.

Through the window, the city appeared in slivers: dark water, clusters of light, hills like sleeping animals. From above it looked almost gentle. Grace thought of her father's hands — big, warm hands that used to smell faintly of ink and watch metal — and felt her throat tighten. He used to say, half-smiling, don't let the city see you bleed. It had sounded dramatic when she was a teenager. It no longer did.

The captain welcomed them in English, then Cantonese. The second language made her body flinch with familiarity. The wheels touched down. People clapped softly, as if survival deserved applause. Grace stared at her hands and wondered whether she was arriving to say goodbye or to maintain a family myth nobody wanted to let die.

In the jet bridge the air was too cold and too clean, disinfectant masquerading as morality. Fluorescent light flattened everyone into the same tired colour. Signs in English above Chinese pointed with the certainty of a city that did not enjoy questions.

Temporary, her mother had said. In the measured flow of arrivals, it sounded like something the family had trained itself to believe. Temporary was how panic became a schedule. Temporary was how a daughter was kept compliant without anyone having to call it obedience.

Grace joined the stream towards immigration, rolling her carry-on. The e-Channel gates blinked green like an invitation to pretend you were not arriving into anything emotional. She stepped forward, let the machine take her face and fingerprints, and the barrier opened with a soft click that sounded like agreement. There was no welcome home. There was only access.

Baggage reclaim smelled of rubber belts and duty-free perfume. Her cases arrived quickly — two identical hard shells with familiar scuffs. She took the trolley handle for a moment, then released it when an airport porter approached.

"Need help, miss?" he asked in Cantonese.

Grace answered in English without thinking, then corrected herself with a brief phrase that sounded rustier than she wanted. The porter did not react. He stacked the cases with care — handles aligned, tags outward — order as a form of respect. Grace followed a step behind.

The arrivals hall was bright and relentless, full of people waiting for other people's lives to arrive. Grace saw her

mother immediately. Some women disappeared into crowds. Her mother organised them.

She was dressed as if for lunch at the Club: pale silk, scarf arranged with casual precision, hair immaculate. No jewellery that shouted, only the kind that whispered to people who listened. She held herself still with a phone in one hand, the other resting lightly on the barrier as if she owned it.

"Grace," her mother said as the side gate opened. Not a greeting. Merely the syllables by which rooms in this city resumed their intended shape. She kissed both cheeks, quick and careful, then held her for exactly as long as affection was permitted to last. The embrace smelled faintly of powder and expensive flowers. Grace felt, absurdly, the urge to cling. She did not.

"Mum," she said. She meant it to be warm. It came out like a greeting at a meeting.

For a second she saw the shape of what was missing. Her father used to meet her at arrivals when she was younger — always positioned a little apart from the crowd, always making it look as if he had been waiting for minutes rather than hours. He would say something lightly teasing about her suitcase, about the weight of books, about how she travelled like a person moving house. He would touch her hair once, brief and fond, and she would pretend not to like it. Now there was only her mother's perfume and her

mother's calm, and the absence of him felt like a hole the airport could not fill.

"Have you eaten?" her mother asked, already scanning Grace's face like a checklist.

"On the plane," Grace lied.

"Good." Her mother did not waste time on lies that kept the machine moving. "Straight to the hospital. No detours. Your room is ready if you need to change later, but not now. Your father had a good night. He's stable."

Stable. The word dropped between them like a coin.

Grace tried to speak and stopped. The question she wanted to ask — Is he still in there? — was too raw for this lighting. Her mother filled the gap with the version she had chosen. "He knows you're here."

Grace did not trust the statement, and hated herself for not trusting it.

A message flashed on her mother's screen — Catherine — and disappeared under two quick taps. Her mother looked up as if nothing had happened. "People have been asking after you," she said. "They're relieved you're here."

Relieved. Not missed. Not loved.

"Keep your phone away for now," her mother added, almost casually, as if advising Grace not to forget a scarf. "No posts. Not even something harmless. People talk." She did not specify who. She never had to.

A security officer lifted a barrier rope without being asked. "Mrs Purvis," he said, neutral and respectful. Her mother acknowledged him with the smallest tilt of her chin, not gratitude — confirmation. Grace followed, half a step behind without meaning to, already back in a lane she had not chosen.

Near the ground transport exit, service lanes unfolded: hotel staff with discreet placards, private drivers at designated points, porters transferring luggage from one set of hands to another. Grace clocked the choreography because she could not help it. Hong Kong was a city of choreography. Even grief had a place to stand.

In the lane to their left, a Peninsula representative in green held the relaxed attentiveness of someone paid to make wealth feel safe. Beside him stood the man from baggage reclaim — the one who had spoken Cantonese with the calm of someone who belonged here.

The wrong porter reached for the wrong trolley. It was not slapstick; it was the ordinary entropy of high service. The trolley began to turn towards the Peninsula lane.

The man spoke. He did not raise his voice. He did not say you are wrong. He said something in Cantonese that sounded formal, careful, almost apologetic, as if the mistake were his own. The porter stopped. A light gesture — not accusing, only indicating — and the porter's face flickered with embarrassment before smoothing back to

professional blankness. One more sentence, softer. The porter relaxed. He had been given an exit. No one had lost face. The trolley turned back; tags were checked; reality was corrected without rupture.

Grace felt her attention sharpen. She thought of her father — how he could make decisions sound like favours — and felt guilt arrive immediately, neat and sharp.

The man's eyes lifted and met Grace's for half a beat too long to be purely incidental. Then he looked away first, choosing restraint. He spoke to the Peninsula representative in English — thank you, that's fine — his accent neither British nor American, not interested in announcing itself.

Outside, a Peninsula-green Rolls waited, absurdly glossy, a colour chosen to be recognised at a distance. The number plate was heavy on 8s. Her father used to pronounce faat with theatrical delight whilst her mother rolled her eyes. Seeing the plate now made Grace's mouth tighten with the old mixture of amusement and disgust.

The man walked to the car as if it were merely transport. The door shut with a sound more muffled than most car doors, as if noise were an indignity.

Grace's family car was waiting one lane over. She slid into the back seat beside her mother and felt herself being returned to a container.

Her mother checked her phone the way other women checked a pulse. When it rang, she answered on the first tone. "Yes," she said, voice softening into the professional kindness she used for doctors. "We've just left arrivals. Ten minutes. Yes, I understand. Keep him comfortable." A pause. "No, not yet." She ended the call and placed the phone back in her lap with the same calm she would have used for a napkin.

"What did he say?" Grace asked, and heard the plea in the question despite herself.

"They're monitoring," her mother replied. "He needs rest. You need to look steady when you go in. Don't ask questions in the corridor. If you want to ask something, you do it in the room."

"Why?" Grace kept her voice low.

"Because people listen," her mother said.

At the junction the car paused, then merged. Through the windscreen Grace caught a last glimpse of the terminal doors opening and closing like eyelids. Ahead, the Peninsula Rolls flashed green between vehicles for a second before being swallowed by traffic.

Her mother smoothed Grace's sleeve once — an almost intimate gesture that was also correction. "No melodrama," she said softly, not unkind. "You will have time to feel later."

Grace looked out at the city sliding past and wondered what later meant in this family. Later could be after dinner. Later could be never.

"We don't have long," her mother said, calm as a schedule. Grace stared at her hands and tried to decide whether her mother meant visiting hours, the day, or her father's life.

## CHAPTER II — VELVET COMMAND

The car was so quiet it felt upholstered against panic.

Grace sat beside her mother and watched the terminal's silver curves slide past through tinted glass, then give way to road, cones, and the careful choreography of lanes. The driver eased them forward with the same quiet competence the porter had used with the trolley, and Grace felt the old petty insult of it: how many hands existed in her life purely to remove friction, and how easily friction had become her only proof of agency.

For a few seconds the Peninsula-green Rolls remained ahead of them, a glossy flash between vehicles, then it vanished into the flow. Grace did not know whether she was relieved or disappointed. Both felt like treason. She told herself she had noticed only the colour, the vulgar serenity of a car that seemed to move without sound. She had not, she told herself, stored the half-second when the man from baggage reclaim had looked at her and then away. It should have meant nothing. A stranger corrected a porter. Yet her mind, already raw, had kept it with the wrong kind of care.

Her mother held her phone in her lap, screen dark. She looked forward, not out of interest in traffic but out of habit; people like her did not crane to see where they were going. They were taken.

Her mother checked her watch once, then said to the driver, "Fifteen minutes." The instruction was calm, administrative, and not addressed to Grace, which made it land harder.

"Why does everything have rules?" Grace asked.

Her mother turned her head a fraction, enough to inspect Grace's face. "Because we live among people. And people talk."

Grace thought of the old table at the Peak house — linen too white, glasses too thin, conversations that sounded like laughter until you listened closely. Someone's daughter had "not coped." Someone's son had been "quietly sent away." A woman was "so brave," which meant disgraced. Reputation was never something you possessed. It was something other people temporarily granted.

"You can fall apart," her mother said, and for a heartbeat Grace felt almost hopeful. Then the sentence completed itself, neat as a trap. "But you do it in the right place."

Not because crying was wrong, but because crying could be seen. Questions announced need, and need invited management. Back here, training rose in her like muscle memory: shoulders back, voice level, face composed, do not reach for anyone in public.

The bridge came up and the water opened beneath them — dark, patient, holding ships that moved so slowly they made time itself look negotiable.

Her father would once have made a joke of the skyline. He would have pointed out who owned what, which tower had overpaid for itself, which banker had married into which family and regretted it too late. He could turn anything into story if it threatened to become feeling. Now there was only the water and her mother's calm, and the two felt equally still.

Her mother reached into her handbag and produced a small packet of tissues, then set it on the seat between them without comment, like an object placed in readiness for weather.

Grace stared at it. "For what."

"For whatever happens," her mother said, and the honesty of it was almost startling. Then she softened it at once. "Hospitals are dry."

The phone lit up again. This time Grace saw the name clearly: Catherine.

Her mother let it ring twice before answering in the voice she used with doctors and women who mattered. "Catherine." Grace turned her face towards the window, pretending not to listen — a habit from childhood: hear everything, reveal nothing.

"Yes," her mother said. "She's here. We're on our way now." A pause. "Not tonight. No. We'll see how he is. Tomorrow at the earliest." Another pause, shorter, the kind that meant Catherine was insisting. Grace heard the

small polished laugh her mother reserved for pressure she intended to manage rather than refuse. "You can send flowers to the house," she said. "Not the hospital. The hospital does not need a photograph."

Something in Grace's throat tightened with sudden, irrational gratitude. Flowers were innocent. Photographs were evidence. Catherine's kindness arrived with witnesses.

Her mother ended the call and placed the phone back in her lap as if she had merely adjusted the air-conditioning. She did not explain what she had done. She rarely narrated management. She simply performed it.

"That was Catherine," Grace said, because silence was starting to feel like complicity.

"Yes," her mother replied. "She means well."

Grace almost laughed. Meaning well was one of the city's most efficient ways to do harm.

"What did she want?"

"To help," her mother said. "To arrange something. To make sure people do not bother you."

"People are already bothering me," Grace said, and surprised herself with the bitterness.

Her mother's gaze flicked to her. "Grace." The word did what it had always done: stopped. She did not sound impatient. She sounded gently disappointed, which was worse.

"You're tired," she added. "And frightened. That's normal. But you must be careful."

"What if I want to talk to him alone?" Grace asked. It surprised them both. It was the first thing she had said that sounded like desire rather than duty.

Her mother was quiet for a moment. "You can," she said. "If he's awake."

"And if he's not."

"Then you can still talk. He may hear you."

Grace did not know whether to believe that. She did not know whether she wanted to. Talking to a body that could not answer felt perilously close to performance, and performance was already crowding every surface of the day.

They entered the tunnel and the world became a long tube of concrete and light. Orange lamps repeated at measured intervals, a metronome for fear.

"You spoke to the doctor," she said, because she needed something factual to hold.

"Yes."

"What did he say, really?"

Her mother turned her head, and for a heartbeat her face looked older — not in age, in effort. Calm in her had never been the absence of fear. It was discipline.

"He said your father is comfortable," she replied. "The sedation is working. They are watching the swelling. They are hopeful."

Hopeful. The word sat in the car like another soft object waiting to be used. Grace wanted to ask what it meant, but heard her mother's earlier sentence as though the corridor had already begun around them: not here. Not where people listen.

The tunnel gave way to daylight and the city rose in its usual layers: buildings stacked like arguments, scaffolding clinging to everything, Hong Kong always in the middle of becoming itself. Her mother's phone buzzed once more. Grace caught only the first letter of the name before the screen was turned away, but that was enough. Augusta.

"People will worry," her mother said, as though explaining weather. "Worry turns into talk. Talk turns into stories."

"And stories turn into what?" Grace asked.

"Complications."

They took the exit towards the hospital district. Buildings sat closer to the road here — older concrete, layers of repainting, flyovers stacked like decisions. Grace caught a flash of harbour between towers and felt sudden anger at its indifference. The city was still beautiful. The city was still itself. Only her life had been rearranged.

"Do you want to stop at the house first?" her mother asked.

"No. Hospital."

"Good." The approval landed like a hand on the head.

"I should have brought something," Grace said, hating the smallness of it. "Flowers."

"The hospital has enough flowers," her mother said. "Flowers are for people who need to be seen visiting."

"Do we need to be seen?"

Her mother's mouth tightened. "Grace, you are not a child."

"Then stop treating me like one."

Silence filled the back seat, clean and hard. Even the driver seemed to reduce his presence. Finally her mother spoke, still gentle, still unyielding.

"I am not treating you like a child. I am treating you like someone who is tired and frightened and likely to make mistakes."

"And what happens if I make mistakes?"

Her mother looked out at the city. "Then people will take over."

"People like you."

"People like anyone," her mother said. "People who believe they are helping."

The hospital complex appeared ahead — white walls, glass, a covered entrance built to make money look like mercy. Humidity pressed against the sealed car windows as they rolled under the drop-off. Her mother's posture shifted; composition went on like a garment being fastened.

"Remember," she said softly. "No questions in the corridor. Smile at the nurses. Thank them. If you need to cry, you do it in the room."

"And if I can't?" Grace whispered.

For a moment the matriarch fell away and a tired woman appeared beneath the silk and the certainty. Grace saw, with an unpleasant shock, the cost of never collapsing. It startled her more than anger would have.

"Then you breathe," her mother said, barely audible. "And you try again."

The car stopped. A staff member appeared to open doors, to take weight, to smooth the transition from road to building. Grace stepped out into damp air and disinfectant scent, and thought — unbidden, for the second time that day — of the man at the airport. The formal Cantonese. The face-saving correction. The deliberate looking away. Her father was upstairs under machines and she was thinking about a stranger. She noted both facts and did not know what to do with either.

Her mother's hand found Grace's sleeve. "Steady," she murmured, and walked towards the doors as if she had already decided what kind of day this would be.

## CHAPTER III — STABLE

The hospital received them in marble and refrigerated calm.

The air smelled of expensive flowers chosen not to offend. Everything was too bright, too clean, too calmly organised — voices kept low by instinct rather than instruction. Grace followed her mother across the lobby and felt the old sensation of being moved. Not carried — her feet worked, her body obeyed — but moved in the way furniture is moved in a well-run room: quietly, efficiently, without being asked whether it has somewhere else it would rather be.

At reception her mother spoke in formal Cantonese, polite enough to preserve dignity and precise enough to produce outcomes. A badge was printed and slid across the counter with a soft plastic sound. Her mother handed it to Grace without looking down.

"Put it on," she murmured.

Grace pinned it to her blouse. PURVIS, GRACE sat against her chest like a label. No title. No explanation. Just name and family.

The lift rose too quietly. The carpeted corridor above smelled faintly of lavender trying to disguise antiseptic. Here the sound changed into a hush that felt purchased: doors closing softly, machines humming discreetly,

footsteps muffled as if sorrow should not be heard. A nurse in pale blue met them halfway down.

"How is he?" Grace asked before she could stop herself.

The nurse's smile did not change, but her eyes flicked — briefly — to Grace's mother, as if checking where truth was allowed to land. "He is stable," she said. "The consultant will speak with you shortly."

Stable.

The word fell into Grace's palm like a coin: small, cold, and useless. Her mother nodded as though she had been given a useful object. "Thank you," she said, and her thank you sounded sincere enough to be real.

As the nurse moved on, her mother said quietly, "Not here."

Grace swallowed whatever came next.

They stopped outside Room 818. The number was displayed in brushed steel, almost elegant. Her mother put her hand on the handle — not prayer, not exactly, only timing — and pushed.

Soft light. Curtains half-drawn. Orchids on a side table, white and immaculate. A sofa and two armchairs arranged as if this were somewhere people might choose to spend time. Private hospitals always looked like hotels pretending not to be afraid of death.

Her father lay in the bed with his head slightly elevated. Tubes ran from him in neat lines. A monitor glowed with

numbers that meant something to staff and almost nothing to families. His chest rose and fell with deliberate slowness. His face looked both familiar and wrong: the man she knew reduced to skin, breath, and a closed mouth.

Grace's body reacted before her mind did. Throat tightening. Skin cooling. The room tipping slightly, as if gravity had altered.

Her mother crossed to the bedside and set one hand over his. "Darling," she said. "Grace is here."

The word was not false. That was one of the things that made her mother so dangerous. Nothing had to be false to become unusable.

Grace stepped closer. She searched his face for a sign — anything — that he was inside it. A twitch, a flicker, a trace of recognition. There was nothing she could hold. She took his hand. It was warm, and that warmth hurt more than cold would have. Warmth implied presence. Warmth was chemistry.

"Hi," she said. Then, because the first word sounded wrong in the room, "Hi, Dad."

No response. Only the monitor's steady beep, indifferent to whether she was his daughter or merely another body in the room.

The door opened and the consultant entered with the composed briskness of someone who had learned how to ration human expression professionally. He greeted her

mother first, then Grace, and spoke in English. Grace noticed her mother relax by a fraction; English was safer in rooms like this. Cantonese could carry too much family.
"Mrs Purvis. Ms Purvis." He gave the bed a brief professional glance before continuing. "He remains stable. We're continuing sedation to allow the brain to rest. Pressure is being monitored closely."
"Will he wake?" Grace asked, because the question was a splinter she could not stop touching.
"We hope so," the doctor said. "It is too early to predict. Recovery, if it occurs, will be gradual."
Her mother asked, "So there is reason to be encouraged."
The doctor did not contradict her. "There is no reason to abandon hope," he said. Not the same sentence. Close enough to function as one.
He spoke a little longer — careful, hedged, correct — then excused himself with the promise of updates that were really promises of managed language.
When the door closed, her mother released a breath she had not admitted holding.
"You see?" she said softly. "We just need to get through the next day or two. Then it will be clearer."
Grace looked at the bed. It did not look like anything was becoming clearer. It looked like her father had been translated into a set of numbers and calm verbs and left there for everyone else to work around.

Her mother's phone buzzed. She glanced at it, typed one reply, and stood as if leaving a meeting rather than a bedside. "I'm going to take this in the corridor. Don't upset yourself before lunch."

Before lunch. The phrase sat in the room like a domestic object placed neatly on a sideboard.

The door clicked shut. Silence thickened.

Grace sat beside the bed and tried to let herself feel what she had been postponing since the wheels touched the runway. It came in fragments. Love for the man in the bed. Terror that he might never open his eyes again. Anger at her mother's calm. Shame at her own obedience.

She leaned forward and spoke softly. "Dad. I'm here."

No response. Only numbers.

Her eyes moved around the room. A side cabinet stood against the wall with a small lock, the sort private hospitals used for valuables. She stood and moved towards it. The gesture felt intrusive. It also felt necessary.

Inside was a clear bag labelled with his name and the date: PERSONAL EFFECTS.

The phrase felt obscene.

She unzipped the bag carefully. His watch. His ring. A few folded banknotes. His wallet. And his pen — a heavy fountain pen he insisted on carrying even when everyone else used phones. It smelled faintly of his cologne and

metal and ink, as if his hand had been there recently enough to leave a trace.

She touched it and a memory arrived, sharp and ordinary. Her father at the dining table, opening a letter too quickly, the paper catching the side of his thumb. He had stared at the tiny bead of blood and laughed.

"Injured by stationery," he said, and then, because he could never resist making meaning where it was not wanted, "Be careful with paper. It looks harmless."

Grace had been twelve. Worried and irritated at once. He had handed her the envelope as if making her part of the joke, the small scar near his thumb later becoming one of those details you carried without knowing why.

She could still see the pen in his hand at dinners, heavy and old-fashioned against the white linen, refusing to let convenience erase ceremony. He did not flourish it. He did not turn it into a statement. He simply used it — signing a card, writing a name, adding a line to a cheque — with the quiet insistence of a man who liked things to be definite. Men around him borrowed whatever biro appeared; her father reached into his own pocket and produced weight, ink, permanence.

The machines could keep his body warm. They could not keep that.

She rolled the pen once between her fingers and felt the ridges of the cap, the deliberate weight he had trusted against his hand.

She did not want it to become a symbol. She wanted it to be what it was: a small piece of him that was not managed language, not stable, not a photograph arranged for other people. Something she could hold without asking permission. Something that belonged to her alone, if only for tonight.

She pocketed the pen before she could dignify the act with meaning.

When she went back to the bed and took his hand again, the pen sat heavy against her thigh — a small illicit fact.

A quiet knock. The door opened and Theresa slipped inside with a paper bag in one hand and the careful gait of someone entering a room where she did not want to be noticed. Her eyes went to Grace's face before they went to the bed.

"You look like you haven't eaten," Theresa whispered.

"I'm fine," Grace said automatically.

Theresa did not argue. She placed the bag on the side table. "There's soup in there before they make you sit through some dreadful lunch."

She glanced at the monitor with the wary respect of someone who knew machines were both saving and stealing.

"He looks peaceful," she said, and Grace heard how careful the word was. Not better. Not improving. Peaceful.

"He's stable," Grace said, and heard the word leave her mouth like something borrowed.

Theresa's eyes moved to her.

"Stable is a word," she said softly.

## CHAPTER IV — THE ECOSYSTEM

The lift deposited them back into the hospital lobby as if nothing had happened upstairs.

Down here, private grief altered very little. At one side of the lobby a man in a blazer was asking whether the parking validation still applied after six. Near the café, someone stood considering the muffins with the attention of a person who had not yet been told that the world was supposed to have stopped.

Grace walked beside her mother through the bright marble space and felt the eighth floor thinning behind her. Upstairs there had been her father's hand, warm and heavy, the monitor, the pen. Down here there were rolling suitcases, a florist's arrangement in a low glass bowl, a porter steering an empty wheelchair back towards the lifts. Her father had not ceased to matter. The world had simply resumed requiring proof that he mattered to it in turn.

At reception her mother stopped to speak to the woman behind the desk in formal Cantonese, polished enough to sound like courtesy and precise enough to produce outcomes. Grace caught fragments: the consultant's surname, the nurse's title, the time of the next update. A small card was printed and slid across the counter. Her mother tucked it into her wallet without looking down.

Outside, the air hit Grace like a damp hand. Cars hissed past on wet roads. A taxi horn sounded, impatient and alive. Somewhere further down the pavement a man laughed too loudly, proving he was not afraid.

The driver stood by the car with the rear door already open. Grace slid in beside her mother and felt the pen press against her thigh. She kept both hands still.

“We’ll go home,” her mother said. “You will eat. Then you will rest.”

“I’m not tired.”

Her mother’s gaze flicked to her and away. “You’re exhausted. And your face is tired.”

Grace felt heat rise. “My face.”

“It’s what people will see.” Her mother said it gently, which made it worse. “They won’t see your thoughts. They won’t see what you carry.”

A message pinged on her mother’s phone. A glance. A reply typed with both thumbs.

“Catherine is sending something,” her mother said. “Flowers. A note. She means well.”

“I don’t want visitors,” Grace said.

Her mother let silence do half the work of correction. When she finally answered, Grace already felt twelve.

“You will have visitors. For your father. People need to feel included. If they don’t, they become anxious.”

“And anxious people do foolish things,” Grace said.

Her mother gave a brief look that might, in another life, have counted as approval. “Exactly.”

Behind trimmed hedges and discreet stone, the house was already waiting.

Inside, the air was cooled and faintly floral. Someone took Grace’s coat. Someone else appeared with tea already poured. The whole house smelled of polished wood, citrus cleaning products, and fresh flowers that had been replaced while she was in the air. Grace had always thought that smell belonged to stability. Today it smelled like replacement.

“Eat,” her mother said, as if the word itself possessed curative properties.

A plate had been set before she crossed the threshold. Rice, greens, a piece of steamed fish. No choices. No spectacle. Care presented as inevitability. She took one bite because refusing would be read as drama.

Her mind kept returning to her father’s face under the hospital light, to the warmth of his hand, to the monitor’s steady beep.

“I want to go back,” she said.

Her mother set down her fork. “Not now.”

“He may wake.”

“If he wakes, they will call.”

“And if he doesn’t.”

Her mother's gaze stayed calm. "Then sitting by the bed for another hour changes nothing except your exhaustion."

Not cruelty. Arithmetic. That was always harder to fight.

"He would want you to rest," her mother said, more softly.

Grace felt something flare. "You don't know what he would want."

For half a beat the room changed temperature. Then her mother said, "Grace," and the name functioned as it always had — a hand laid lightly across the wrist before a glass could be broken.

"Don't fight me."

"I'm not fighting you," Grace lied.

Her mother's phone buzzed. "Catherine will be here in twenty minutes."

Grace looked up. "Why."

"Because she wants to help."

"She doesn't help. She positions."

Her mother's face altered by a degree. Not annoyance. Something colder and more efficient. "That's the same thing," she said.

Grace looked down at the plate. The food tasted of nothing.

The doorbell rang eighteen minutes later.

The staff moved first — one to the door, another to take flowers, another to bring fresh cups. The house always preferred to meet the world halfway down the corridor so the world could enter already softened. Grace heard

Catherine before she saw her. Some women announced themselves by volume. Catherine did it by direction. Wherever she stood, the room quietly re-ordered around her.

She entered carrying a bouquet that looked expensive and restrained enough to claim seriousness. White orchids, green stems, no gaudy colour. She kissed Grace's mother first, then Grace. Her perfume reached the dining room a second before she did.

"My darling," she said, and the endearment contained affection, possession, and social claim in equal measure. "We were all so worried."

Grace murmured something polite. Catherine's eyes skimmed her face — not with cruelty, but with appraisal. Catherine could tell whether you had slept, eaten, or cried. She could read weakness like a language.

"How is he," Catherine asked, and the question was sincere enough to be believable.

"Stable," Grace's mother replied before Grace could speak. Catherine nodded with exactly the correct amount of relief. "Good. That's good."

It was not good. Stable was indefinite. Stable was waiting. Grace said nothing.

Catherine sat at the table without being invited because invitation would have implied uncertainty. Staff appeared with tea for her as naturally as if she lived there. She

accepted the cup with absent gratitude and began talking at once in the register Grace had come to recognise as Catherine's most dangerous one: practical kindness.

Who had been told. Which Foundation calls had been managed. Which dinners could be postponed. Which appearances could be quietly dropped without producing offence. Which messages should not be answered at all because answering them would generate more messages. She spoke of people the way weather bulletins spoke of pressure systems — not unfeelingly, but with the assumption that what mattered was movement, not souls. Grace listened for almost a minute before realising Catherine had already begun rearranging the next two days around her without once pretending the right to do so was in question.

"The gala in two days," Catherine said. "It would be good for people to see you."

Grace felt something in her chest tighten. "Why are we talking about galas."

"Because life continues," Catherine replied, and the phrase arrived as both consolation and threat. "And because your father would want things to remain steady."

Her mother's eyes flicked to Catherine. Agreement passing silently between two women who did not need to waste words on alignment.

Catherine leaned forward. “Nothing strenuous. You won’t be expected to stay late. But people will look too hard at absence.”

Her mother unfolded her napkin as though the matter had already been settled. “We can’t vanish,” she said.

Grace looked from one woman to the other. “I’m not a public statement.”

“No,” Catherine said. “You’re the opposite. You’re family.”

The sentence entered the room with a softness so complete it almost disguised its teeth.

Catherine reached for the seating sheet she had brought in her bag — of course she had brought one — and laid it on the table between the teacups and the untouched half of Grace’s fish. Names in neat columns, table numbers, pencilled marks in Catherine’s hand.

“I’ve moved you to my side,” she said.

Grace looked at the page. “Without asking.”

Catherine gave the tiniest of smiles. “If I’d asked, you would have said no.”

“That’s a reason not to do it.”

“No,” Catherine replied. “That’s a reason to do it quickly.”

Her mother’s eyes remained on the seating sheet. The economy of that gesture said more than agreement would have.

Catherine traced one manicured finger further down the page. “There is one person I’d like you to meet. Swiss.

Banker. Very discreet. He's newly arrived and will likely be involved in something sensitive."

Grace felt her body go still.

"He'll be at your table," Catherine continued. "You don't need to do anything except be civil."

The formal Cantonese. The face-saving correction. The green Rolls sliding away into traffic.

Catherine noticed the stillness at once. She noticed everything.

"You've met him?" she asked.

Grace forced a small smile. "No," she lied.

Catherine's gaze stayed on her for a beat longer than the answer required. Then she smiled and let the lie pass, either because she believed it or because she had no present use for disputing it.

"You will," she said.

Grace sat very still and listened while Catherine and her mother wove the next two days into a sequence of meals, appearances, hospital visits, and manageable gaps, speaking over the seating chart as if schedule could keep death from becoming rude.

Outside, dusk had begun pressing against the windows. Somewhere upstairs a staff member moved quietly through Grace's room, preparing for a night she had not yet been permitted to imagine.

The ecosystem had returned around her — soft, polite, already tightening.

## CHAPTER V — UPPER DECK

After Catherine left, the house lowered its volume.

Not into silence. Into that expensive near-silence wealthy houses preferred: the hum of air-conditioning, the softened clearing of plates, a tap clicking twice in a distant bathroom. The house did not sleep. It merely agreed to make itself less audible.

Grace lay in bed and tried, for nearly an hour, to do what her mother had prescribed. Rest. Eat. Sleep. Her body was exhausted, but her mind kept circling the same small collection of nouns, as though one of them might eventually open.

Stable. Gala. Banker. Useful. Table.

Catherine's laughter still seemed to cling to the corners of the room, the sound of someone making herself indispensable. When Grace closed her eyes she saw her father's face under the hospital light: familiar and wrong. Not dead. Not present. The monitor's beep kept returning in memory like a metronome she had not agreed to hear.

She got out of bed without deciding to. The floor was cool under her feet. In the bathroom she ran the tap and watched water move over porcelain, then stared at her own face in the mirror. She looked fine. That was the problem. She looked like a woman who had returned from a trip, not a woman whose father might never open his eyes again.

She watched herself practise the expression she would wear in two days. She did not mean to. It happened anyway: a softening around the eyes, a calm mouth, tiredness shaped into devotion rather than strain. She stopped only when she realised what she was doing and felt shame arrive immediately after. The city rewarded women who looked like they were coping. It punished women who looked like they were not.

Back in the bedroom the silence felt too clean. She could imagine her mother down the corridor — not asleep so much as paused, phone by the bed, mind still moving through names, routes, timings. Her mother did not sleep when control was at stake. She reduced activity. That was different.

Grace sat on the edge of the bed and felt the old, petty urge to disobey simply to prove she could.

She dressed quietly: dark trousers, a light jumper, flats. Nothing that belonged to the daughter in the Foundation circular. Nothing that could be photographed and interpreted. She took a small bag and slid her phone into it without checking the screen. Tonight she did not want words. She wanted motion.

In the corridor the lights were dimmed, not off — old money never fully surrendered to darkness. At the top of the stairs she paused and listened. The house held its breath. Each step down felt like a decision, which was

absurd. Leaving your own house at night should not feel like a moral act. Yet here it did, because in this house every act had the potential to become a story by breakfast.

Halfway down, a staff door opened and the night woman appeared, eyes briefly startled. She looked at Grace and then reflexively looked past her, as if expecting the matriarch to materialise just behind.

"Miss Grace?" she said softly, in Cantonese.

"I couldn't sleep," Grace replied in English, then corrected herself in Cantonese, the words clumsy with disuse. "I'm going out for a little while."

The woman's expression stayed neutral, but Grace saw the calculation in her eyes: should I tell madam, should I call the driver, is this permitted. "Do you want the car?" she asked, already offering the smooth, correct solution.

Grace's first instinct was yes. The car was how this family moved. The car made everything quiet. The car kept you from being seen. Then she felt the hidden cost at once: a driver meant a report, a route, a piece of narrative someone else would possess by morning.

"No," she said. "I'll take a taxi."

The woman hesitated. "Madam—"

Grace cut in gently. "I'll be back soon. Don't wake her."

It was a request for disobedience, small and precise. The woman nodded once, eyes lowering, and Grace understood she had just purchased a favour with the only

currency staff valued in houses like this: not money, but the promise of a quieter night than the one already underway.

Outside, humidity met her skin like a hand. The driveway light cast a pale pool on the ground; beyond the gate, the city murmured. She walked to the corner where taxis sometimes waited, her heart beating too fast for a simple errand. A red taxi appeared within minutes, the driver half-asleep behind the wheel. Grace gave an address without thinking too hard — Central, near the tram line — and the driver nodded and pulled away as though she had asked for milk.

As they descended, the Peak roads curved through darkness and trees and then the lights began, scattered at first and then clustering into density. Hong Kong at night always looked designed rather than built: neon, reflected glass, traffic moving in steady red and white streams. The driver listened to a radio programme at low volume, Cantonese voices arguing gently and then laughing. The language slid over Grace's skin in a way English did not. She caught tone, not content, and was grateful for the blur.

When the taxi reached Central the air felt heavier, more concrete, less forgiving. People still moved as though it were early evening: men in shirtsleeves smoking outside a bar, a couple stumbling out of a restaurant, a delivery worker wheeling boxes into a service entrance with a face

blank from routine. Grace paid, stepped onto the pavement, and stood still for a moment just to listen.

Then she heard it.

The bell came faintly at first, a soft double chime that could have belonged to anything. Then it came again — ding-ding — clearer, and her body reacted before her mind did. Her shoulders dropped by a fraction. The space behind her ribs loosened. The sound reached somewhere the hospital and the house had not yet touched.

The tram arrived with its stubborn slowness, a box of light moving through the city as if time were negotiable. It looked old beside the modern glass, and that oldness felt like comfort. Grace tapped her Octopus card and climbed the narrow stairs to the upper deck. The tram smelled faintly of varnished wood, damp fabric, and metal. Up here the air was warmer, less controlled.

She took the very front seat, the one with the wide view through the front window.

When she was younger, this had been her place. She liked it because nobody could see her face from behind. She liked it because she could watch the city without being watched. Most of all she liked it because the tram's motion meant she did not have to decide where to go. The city decided for her, one stop at a time.

Tonight, the seat was empty. Grace sat and felt something unclench — not joy, not relief exactly, but a loosening of

the vigilance she had been carrying since touchdown. The tram began to move, slow and steady, and the city slid forward.

She had come here because it was the only place she could be alone without making a statement. In the house, being alone would be interpreted. In the hospital, being alone would be monitored. On the tram, being alone was ordinary.

Neon signs blurred on wet pavement. A bus passed, interior full of tired faces. Shops stood half-open, half-closed, the city never entirely asleep. A handful of passengers sat upstairs — an older man with a shopping bag, a young woman scrolling through her phone, a couple holding hands without speaking. Nobody looked at Grace. Nobody cared. That indifference felt like mercy.

The bell sounded at an intersection. Ding-ding. Cars paused. People stepped back. For a moment everything obeyed this small old vehicle without complaint. Grace leaned her head back and closed her eyes for a heartbeat. When she opened them again she was not in a private ward. She was not at her mother's table being told to eat. She was simply moving through a city that, for twenty minutes at least, did not require her face to mean anything useful.

A memory arrived with the bell, uninvited and precise.

She had been seventeen and furious at her mother for something petty and enormous — a remark at dinner, a laugh that had not been a laugh. She had stormed out of the house and made it down to the tram line on foot because she wanted punishment, because she wanted wet air on her skin as proof she was alive. She had taken the front seat and stared through the window at the lights until the anger began changing shape.

Her father had found her later — not by chasing her down in anger, but by appearing quietly at the stop, hands in pockets, hair slightly disordered as if he had decided not to be perfect for once. He had looked up at her sitting at the front and smiled that half-smile that meant he understood. He had not scolded her. He had climbed upstairs and sat behind her without speaking for several stops, letting the tram do the work.

When he finally spoke it had been softly, as though not to break the spell.

"Your mother loves you," he said. "She just loves you like a system."

Grace had laughed then — partly because the phrase was so odd, partly because it was so exact. Her father had added, "It's how she survives," and Grace had wanted to ask, survives what, but she had not. She had watched the city move and felt the anger drain into something else.

Now the memory landed like a bruise pressed too hard. Grace pictured her father on the tram, alive, present, sitting behind her without trying to fix anything. She pictured his hand once — brief and fond — touching her hair as if to remind her she was not alone. She realised she had not allowed herself to think of him like this since landing. She had thought of him as a body and a monitor and a word. Stable. She had not thought of him as the man who understood she needed motion more than instruction.

The tram passed through Wan Chai. Light from bars spilled onto the pavement. A woman in high heels stood smoking outside a shop, phone pressed to her ear, voice sharp. A group of men in loosened ties laughed too loudly, proving they were not afraid. The city looked glamorous and exhausted. Grace thought of Catherine saying life continues and felt the phrase land again as both consolation and threat.

Her phone vibrated in her bag. Grace tensed instinctively and resisted the urge to take it out. The vibration could be anything: her mother, Catherine, a message from abroad. She did not want the world inside this small moving room. The phone stopped. She exhaled slowly and hated the reflexive obedience her mother's instruction had installed: keep it away.

The man from the airport surfaced in her mind again, unwanted. The formal Cantonese. The face-saving correction. The deliberate looking away. She did not want to think about a stranger when her father lay under machines upstairs. Yet her mind kept returning to him, reaching for a door she had already touched. She had noticed him twice already. That was more than she wanted to admit.

Grace stayed on until she reached a point that felt far enough to count as leaving without actually leaving. She did not choose a stop; she chose a sensation — the moment her thoughts felt slightly reordered, the moment her body felt less clenched. When she stepped off, damp air hit her skin and she stood on the pavement watching the tram pull away. The bell sounded once as it left the stop, polite and persistent — ding-ding — and then it was swallowed by the city's wet light.

She did not want to go home. Home meant her mother's calm and scheduled dinners and rules delivered as care. Home meant being watched. Home meant performing steadiness so other people could feel relieved. The rebellion flared and then drained into exhaustion.

She took a taxi back up the hill. The security guard nodded without question. The house loomed quiet and tasteful, holding its breath. Inside, air-conditioning stripped humidity and emotion with equal efficiency. The night

woman appeared again, looked at Grace, then past her. Grace shook her head slightly: don't wake her. The woman nodded and retreated.

Grace climbed the stairs quietly, paused at the top to listen, then went back to her room. She lay down and waited for sleep. Instead she found herself listening for the tram bell as if it were proof there was still a way out.

In the silence of the house, she could still hear it — ding-ding — long after the city had swallowed her again.

## CHAPTER VI — HER TABLE

By late afternoon the ward had already begun to feel like routine, which was its own kind of obscenity.

The consultant returned with the same careful face and the same careful language. Numbers steady. No acute deterioration. Continue as before. The family held to the word stable. Grace watched the phrases land and leave no mark on the bed.

When they stepped back into the corridor, her mother said, with the calm of someone confirming dinner reservations, "We will go tonight."

Grace stopped by the lift. The carpet was too clean under her feet and the lavender in the air was trying too hard.

"Tonight?" she said.

Her mother did not look surprised that Grace had forgotten. Forgetting would have implied Grace still believed she had a schedule of her own. "Catherine's gala," she said. "It is already arranged."

"Mum—"

Her mother turned her head a fraction, enough to offer correction without yet offering argument. "We cannot be absent," she said softly. "Not now."

At home, food appeared at the appointed time. Grace sat because sitting was easier than arguing.

After dinner, a staff member appeared carrying a garment bag.

"Miss Grace," she said softly. "Madam says the navy."

Grace looked at the bag. "The navy?"

"The one with the high neck," the woman clarified, voice neutral enough to make the dress sound like a medical instruction.

Grace could have said no. She knew exactly how that would go: her mother's calm, a faint disappointment, the word practical, and the implication that Grace was making everything harder for everyone. The dress would become an argument, and arguments in this family never disappeared simply because nobody had written them down.

She took the bag and carried it upstairs like a task.

In her room she changed slowly, not from vanity but from fatigue. The dress was beautiful in the way discipline could be beautiful: structured, modest, expensive without shouting, designed to make a woman look like stability. Grace looked at herself in the mirror and felt something inside her shrink. This was not the face of a woman in crisis. This was the face of a daughter performing competence.

Downstairs, her mother waited by the door in pale silk, phone in hand, already prepared. She looked Grace over once — not admiring, assessing — then nodded.

"Good. Don't drink too much. Speak to people, but not for too long. If anyone asks you something you do not want to answer, you smile and say you are taking it one day at a time."

Grace felt her jaw tighten. "Is that what I'm doing?"

Her mother met her eyes. "That is what you will be doing," she said.

The driver brought the car around. They slid into the back seat and left the house behind its gates and foliage. The city beyond was already lit.

They did not speak much on the drive. Her mother answered messages in short, decisive taps. Grace stared out of the window and tried not to think of her father. She failed. She pictured his face under the hospital light, the warmth of his hand, the steady beep. She thought too of

the tram, the front seat, her father's voice saying your mother loves you like a system. The memory did not help. It only made the evening ahead feel more like surrender.

The hotel entrance was lit like a stage. Staff in dark uniforms waited with relaxed readiness, making wealth feel safe. Grace stepped out and felt the air change: cooler, scented, controlled. Inside, the lobby smelled of flowers, citrus polish, and expensive perfume.

Catherine Leung was waiting near the ballroom entrance as though she had been installed there permanently. Black silk. Pearls. The smile of someone who belonged anywhere because she had arranged it so. She moved towards Grace's mother first, kissing her cheek with practised warmth.

"My love," Catherine said, affectionate enough to be believable and possessive enough to be true.

Then she turned to Grace and kissed her cheek. "Darling," she said, and Grace felt the familiar discomfort of being addressed as if Catherine had a claim. "We've all been so worried."

Grace said nothing.

"How is he?" Catherine asked.

"Stable," Grace's mother replied before Grace could speak.

Catherine nodded. "That's good," she said.

"Tonight will do you good," Catherine added. "People will be gentle."

Grace knew what that kind of gentleness was for.

They entered the ballroom and the air shifted — colder, denser, filled with perfume, champagne, and the faint metallic scent of stage lighting. A string quartet played something pretty that nobody listened to properly. Voices layered into a constant murmur, laughter timed, attention distributed like currency.

Theresa Chow approached before Grace could be properly swallowed. Her smile was small and real. She took Grace's hand briefly, a squeeze that said more than words could safely carry.

"You made it," Theresa murmured.

"I didn't have a choice," Grace said, and surprised herself with the honesty.

Theresa's eyes flicked to Grace's mother across the room. "Sometimes that's the same thing," she said softly.

Alistair Pembroke drifted in as if summoned by the mention of a name. Tall, beautifully dressed, smiling as though life were a charming inconvenience. He greeted Grace's mother first, then Catherine, then Grace, distributing warmth like someone handing out napkins.

"Grace Purvis," he said. "Back among us. We missed you."

Grace smiled because smiling was safer than answering. She chose the line her mother had rehearsed. "One day at a time."

Alistair's smile broadened. "Perfect," he murmured.

Catherine announced seating with a soft clap. People moved towards tables with practised efficiency, as if where you sat mattered more than what you ate. Grace's mother guided her forward with a light touch on the elbow, proprietary and polite. Grace felt the familiar nausea of being placed.

At the table, name cards waited like verdicts. Grace found hers: GRACE PURVIS. No hyphen. No marriage name. The family brand intact. She let her eyes slide to the card opposite.

LUC MOREL.

The jolt in her chest was not lust. It was recognition, and something close to dread. Hong Kong did not do coincidence at this level; it did arrangements.

Her mother sat to Grace's left. Catherine sat to Grace's right. Grace understood the positioning at once: held between the family and the ecosystem, anchored so she could not drift.

A waiter offered champagne. Grace hesitated. Her mother's gaze flicked to her. Not a warning. A reminder.

Grace took the flute. Catherine smiled approvingly.

Luc arrived without fuss, stepping into place as if he had been there all along. Dark suit, expensive without looking chosen, hair neat, face calm. He carried himself with the same controlled stillness Grace had clocked at the airport:

the posture of someone who understood rooms and did not need to announce himself to them.

He greeted Grace's mother first, as etiquette demanded. "Mrs Purvis," he said, accent softening English without making it foreign. Her mother nodded, allowing the greeting. He turned to Catherine. "Ms Leung," he said, and Catherine's smile brightened with the pleasure of being named correctly.

Then his eyes came to Grace.

"Ms Purvis," he said.

The syllables landed in Grace's body like oxygen. It was not flirtation. It was accuracy. In a room where she was being treated as stabilising evidence, being addressed as herself felt indecently intimate.

"Mr Morel," she said, and heard the steadiness in her own voice as if it belonged to someone else.

Catherine leaned forward at once, delighted by her own arrangement. "Luc has just arrived," she said brightly, as if he were a new piece of glassware placed in the centre of the table. "Very discreet. Very useful."

Luc smiled politely. "I arrived this morning," he said.

Catherine's eyes gleamed. "Have you two met?"

Grace forced a small smile. "No," she lied.

Luc's eyes flicked to her for the briefest second. He did not expose her. He did not correct Catherine. He let the lie stand.

Catherine launched into "sensitive matters" in euphemisms that sounded like philanthropy and meant money. Luc answered questions with sentences that sounded helpful and revealed almost nothing. Grace recognised the skill. It was the same skill her mother used: keep people calm without giving them anything they could use.

Augusta St John appeared at the edge of the table in cream silk and moral authority. She greeted Catherine, greeted Grace's mother, then turned to Grace with warm solemnity.

"My darling," Augusta said. "How are you holding up?"

Grace murmured something.

"So brave," Augusta said. "So strong."

The same word, from a different mouth.

Augusta's gaze shifted to Luc. Catherine beamed. "Luc Morel," she said, as if introducing an acquisition. "Swiss. Discretion itself."

Augusta smiled at him in a way that implied she could be his friend or his judge. "We must all be careful in times like these," she said softly. Luc acknowledged the sentence as if it were weather. Augusta moved on.

Across the room, Grace noticed Deborah Ho — luminous in pale silk, laughing at something a man beside her said. The laughter made her look effortless. Grace told herself

she did not know who Deborah was. The city, she suspected, was about to tell her.

At one point Luc turned slightly towards her and asked, quietly enough that it might have passed for politeness, "How is your father?"

The question contained no expectation of a socially acceptable answer.

"Stable," she said.

Luc held her gaze for a beat. "Yes," he replied, as if he understood what the word meant and what it did not. Then he looked away again, choosing restraint.

Grace's mother watched the exchange without expression.

Speeches followed. A man from the charity spoke of resilience and community. Applause arrived at the correct points. When the programme ended, guests stood and milled. Hands were shaken. Condolences offered. "We were so worried," people said, offering worry like a gift. "You're so strong," they said, as if strength were not a demand. Grace smiled until her face felt stiff.

When they returned to the table to collect bags, Catherine's hand rested lightly on the back of Grace's chair — proprietary, as if Grace were an object placed correctly and now being checked.

Luc stepped closer, close enough that Grace could feel his presence without him touching her.

"Goodnight, Ms Purvis," he said softly.

The words landed like an expectation.

Grace managed a polite smile. "Goodnight, Mr Morel."

Catherine's hand remained on the chair for a heartbeat longer, then lifted as if granting release. Grace walked beside her mother towards the ballroom doors, face composed, body obedient, mind too awake.

Outside, Hong Kong waited humid and watchful, and Grace realised with a small, sick certainty that she had been seen.

## CHAPTER VII — A NAME

Grace woke with the faint taste of champagne still at the back of her throat and the sensation of being watched lodged under her skin.

The ballroom's cold air, the orchids, the sponsor screen — none of it should have followed her into her bedroom, but it had. She lay still and listened to the house. It was already awake in its quiet, competent way: softened footsteps, the low hum of air-conditioning, the clink of porcelain somewhere that suggested tea had been decided for her before she had decided anything at all.

Stable. Gala. Useful. Morel.

The words were there the moment she opened her eyes, not as thoughts so much as objects arranged in her mind. She reached towards the bedside drawer by reflex and touched the pen where she had hidden it before dressing for the gala. The gesture steadied nothing.

She got out of bed slowly, not because she was tired but because speed felt like confession. In the bathroom mirror her face looked composed enough to be trusted, which irritated her more than the swelling beneath her eyes.

Downstairs, breakfast was already arranged with quiet precision. Fruit cut into neat shapes. Toast. Tea poured, cup placed exactly where her right hand would fall. A bowl of congee sat to one side because it always did, because

some things in this house did not require instruction to reappear. Grace sat and ate because she could already hear the word that would be used about her later — fragile — said with sympathy and meant as warning.

Her mother entered without sound — no stomp of presence, just arrival. Pale silk, phone in hand, face calm in the way that suggested either sleep or discipline; Grace had never been sure which. Her eyes went to Grace's plate first, then to Grace's face, checking compliance and then consequence.

"You ate," her mother observed.

"I'm eating," Grace replied, because it was safer than saying I can't taste anything.

"Good." Her mother sat opposite and poured herself tea without asking. Asking was for people who needed permission. "We'll go to the hospital at ten."

Grace's stomach tightened. "Why not now?"

"Because the consultant will be there at ten. And because you were out late."

"I wasn't out late."

"Grace." The name was a hand on her wrist again. Her mother took a sip of tea and added, as if offering kindness, "You're tired. Your face is tired. There is no point going in looking unsettled."

Grace felt heat rise at the word. She imagined it repeated by someone else: she seems unsettled. Grief as a behavioural flaw.

Her mother's phone lit, screen angled away, and she tapped once with practised certainty. "Catherine sent a message," she said.

Grace's mouth went dry. "About what."

"About last night. She said you were wonderful."

Grace held her spoon still. "Wonderful at what."

"Being present," her mother replied. "People were relieved to see you."

Relieved. The word settled in her chest like a stone.

Her mother added, almost casually, "There will be another event soon. Not a gala. Just coffee. Catherine wants you to meet someone useful."

"I don't want to meet anyone."

Her mother did not argue. She did not need to. "You don't have to want it," she said gently. "You only have to do it."

At ten, the car arrived. Grace slid into the back seat and felt herself returned to the container. The city moved outside the glass. Her mother was on her phone, replying in short decisive taps.

At the hospital, the corridor hush returned. The nurse greeted her mother first. The consultant spoke about monitoring, sedation, the next twenty-four hours. Her father remained what the doctor called stable — a door left

open enough to live with. Grace watched her mother translate possibility into certainty with the same ease she had used to translate Catherine's kindness into obligation. She held her father's hand and felt the warmth and the absence together, an indecent pairing. She wanted to ask whether he would ever say her name again. Instead she asked nothing. Her mother thanked the staff in formal Cantonese and led Grace out when the visit had reached the correct length.

They went from the hospital to lunch with an aunt because that, too, was part of holding together. The restaurant smelled of money pretending to be casual. The food arrived in courses. Her aunt's concern was pitched exactly right — soft shock at the tragedy, admiration at Grace's return, a gentle insistence on strength.

"You're so strong," her aunt said.

Grace smiled because smiling was easier than saying, I haven't had a choice.

Halfway through lunch her phone buzzed from inside her bag and her body tensed. She did not take it out. Her mother glanced at the bag once, then continued talking as if the buzzing did not exist.

Back at the house, her mother went to her study — calls, messages, arrangements — while Grace went upstairs, shut her door, and finally pulled her phone out.

There were messages from abroad, all written in the careful language of those who did not know what to say. A colleague asking whether she needed an extension. An old friend offering love in paragraphs she could not absorb. Theresa's message sat near the top: How are you. Be careful. Call me if you need. Her throat tightened at the bluntness of it. Theresa did not waste words on performance.

Then there was Catherine.

Grace stared at the name for a long moment before opening the message.

Darling, you were wonderful last night. Everyone so relieved to see you. I've just had a thought: something sensitive is coming up and I would love you to meet someone useful. Fifteen minutes. Coffee tomorrow? Lobby bar at the Peninsula. 4pm. Love, C.

Then a second message, almost immediately after:

He will be there. You don't need to do anything. Just meet. Discreet. Helpful. Don't worry, darling. P.S. Deborah Ho means well, but she's enthusiastic — keep it light.

The Peninsula. The green Rolls. The porter's embarrassment smoothed away by formal Cantonese. The deliberate looking away. The name card across the gala table.

Grace felt her pulse jump and hated herself for it. She told herself she did not care about the man. She cared about the

idea of someone who could operate in this world without belonging to her mother. She cared because she was tired and frightened and hungry for something that was not managed.

She texted Theresa: Not fine. Busy. Call later.

Theresa replied almost immediately: I can.

The simplicity of the sentence felt like kindness. Grace called.

"I'm fine," she began automatically.

Theresa cut through it. "No, you're not."

"I'm not," Grace admitted, and the admission loosened something in her chest by a fraction.

Theresa did not ask for details. She did not offer platitudes.

"Your mother?" she said.

"In the study."

Theresa exhaled softly, the sound of someone who understood without needing a lecture. "Be careful," she said, quieter this time. "This isn't just about your father."

Grace looked at Catherine's message and felt the shape of the warning. "I know."

"Deborah Ho," Theresa said, as if continuing a thought she had been holding. "She's asking questions. About the gala. About who was seated where." A beat. "She carries things."

Grace said nothing. She turned her phone face down on the bedspread.

Silence held between them. Theresa spoke first. "If you need to leave the house, leave. Don't ask permission."

Grace almost laughed. Permission was the air she had been raised breathing. "I don't know how."

"You do," Theresa replied. "You just haven't done it in a long time."

Grace closed her eyes. She could hear the house around her — quiet, alert, listening. Even solitude felt served.

When Theresa hung up, Grace stared at Catherine's message again. Fifteen minutes. Lobby bar. Useful. Discreet. The words were arranged to sound harmless. They did not feel harmless. They felt like the first step in a story Catherine had already decided would happen.

She typed a reply and erased it. Typed again and erased it again. The smallest act — accepting coffee — felt like a moral decision, which was absurd. Yet here it did, because everything in this house had already been translated into consequence.

Downstairs, a door opened softly, then closed. A footstep. The house continuing. Her mother moving in her study, making calls, sending messages, arranging the shape of Grace's days as if shape were the same thing as safety.

Grace looked at her reflection in the dark window: a woman in a beautiful house with a father in a private ward and a mother who could turn love into a schedule. She thought of Luc Morel's calm face, his formal Cantonese, his

deliberate restraint, and the way Catherine had framed him with a single word — useful — as if he were a tool she could place on a table.

Grace put the phone down and sat very still.

But the name remained, lingering like a taste she could not swallow or spit out.

## CHAPTER VIII — IGNITION

Grace left the house without asking permission, which already felt like a lie.

She told herself she was stepping out for air. She told herself she was not going out to meet a man. The truth was simpler: she had been invited, and she wanted to go.

Catherine had framed it as nothing. Fifteen minutes. Lobby bar. Discreet. Useful. The words were designed to make resistance look irrational. If Grace refused, she would look fragile. If she went, she would look obedient. The machine always offered you choices like that: two versions of the same cage, one with better lighting.

She dressed in plain clothes — dark trousers, a light top, nothing that could later be described as inappropriate. She left the pen in the drawer. She could not carry her father and Luc at once.

Downstairs, the day staff had the same look the night woman had worn: eyes on Grace, then past her. "Miss Grace." "I'm going out. Taxi." The woman hesitated. Grace shook her head once. The hesitation dissolved. Even now, leaving required somebody else to absorb a portion of the disobedience.

Outside, the air was thick and close. The taxi descended through trees, walls, then the towers beginning.

The Peninsula received her in polished wood, flowers, and expensive restraint. A doorman opened the door before she reached it. The lobby bar sat off to one side, its quiet clink of glass and low conversation suggesting discretion rather than drinking.

Catherine was already there. Of course she was. Cream again — a colour that looked innocent on her and never was. She sat at a corner table with sparkling water and no visible appetite.

"My darling," she said as Grace approached. "I'm so glad you came. I didn't want you alone this afternoon."

Grace heard the double meaning at once: I didn't want you out of sight.

"Thank you," she said, because thank you was what you said when someone offered a hook.

Catherine motioned to the seat opposite. "Sit. You look tired. How is he?"

"The doctors say stable."

Catherine nodded. "That's good." Then, with professional warmth, "We'll all do what we can."

A waiter appeared. Catherine ordered for Grace without asking what she wanted. Grace let her. Choosing in front of Catherine was only another way of declaring material that could later be interpreted.

"He's coming," Catherine said, leaning forward slightly. "He understands our world. And he isn't—" she paused, letting the judgement settle, "foolish."

"Deborah Ho was asking after you," Catherine added lightly. "She means well, but she's enthusiastic — keep it light."

The lobby bar doors opened and Luc stepped in. Grace recognised the controlled stillness before anything else: posture that belonged in rooms, the absence of haste. Dark suit, white shirt open at the throat, everything expensive enough not to need explanation.

He greeted Catherine first, kissing her cheek with European ease. Catherine brightened with the pleasure of a correctly staged arrival. Then he turned to Grace.

"Ms Purvis," he said.

Catherine called her darling as if she owned her. Luc called her Ms Purvis as if she existed. Grace had known it would land the same way it had landed at the gala. It did. She had still not prepared for it.

"Mr Morel," she said, and heard the steadiness in her own voice as if it belonged to someone else.

Catherine filled the air with "sensitive matters" in euphemisms that sounded like philanthropy and meant money. Luc answered with sentences that sounded helpful and revealed nothing. Grace watched his hands — still, controlled — and felt the absurd desire to make him move,

to make him break that stillness. The desire embarrassed her.

Catherine excused herself after exactly fifteen minutes. "I'm just going to say hello to someone," she said. "Don't run away."

The line was a joke, a warning, and a permission structure all at once.

Without Catherine, the room became less supervised and more real. Grace realised with a small, vicious clarity that Catherine's presence had made her feel both safer and less like a person.

Luc said, "How is your father?"

The question contained none of the usual civility. No softening phrase. It sounded like an actual request for an answer rather than an opportunity to display one.

"Stable," she said.

He waited.

It was the waiting that undid her. Most people rushed to save the word once it had been spoken. He left it where it was, small and useless.

"I don't know what it means any more," she said, more quietly.

"Yes," he replied.

The word landed with indecent force. Not because it was kind. Because it did not correct or dilute or repurpose what she had said.

"You were very composed last night," he said.

Grace laughed once, harsh and brief. "Was I."

He chose the word carefully, and the care made it sharper. "You looked managed."

She stared at him. "Don't apologise."

"I wasn't going to." His mouth moved very slightly. "It's not a moral judgement. It's an observation."

"You speak Cantonese," she said, and the sentence came out like accusation.

"Enough. Not perfectly."

"Enough to make a porter not hate himself."

His eyes sharpened, then softened. "Yes."

"Why bother."

"Because it's rude not to." Then, after a beat, "And because it's useful."

The word landed like a hook.

He saw it. His voice lowered. "Not useful as Catherine means it. Useful as in: if you can move through a place without humiliating everyone in it, you should."

"Face," Grace said.

"Yes." He did not flinch from the ugliness of it.

She said, "My mother never named it."

"She wouldn't."

"Why."

"Because once you name a system, people start mistaking it for choice."

Grace looked towards the bar where Catherine was laughing with a man from shipping, one hand on his sleeve, already producing the next arrangement. "She'd say it's care."

Luc did not reply at once. When he did, his voice was low enough that she had to lean to hear. "It probably is."

The sentence landed as the ugliest and most adult thing she had heard all day.

"That's not a defence," Grace said.

"No. It's an observation."

Catherine returned with her smile intact. "There you are. I was beginning to worry you'd both become interesting."

Luc stood. "I should go."

Catherine waved a hand. "Nonsense. Five minutes." Then she checked her watch with performative surprise. "Actually — Grace, you should go. Early night. Hospital tomorrow."

Instructions delivered as care.

Grace stood. Luc stood too, and the symmetry felt like a private joke neither had agreed to acknowledge. "Can I walk you out?" he asked.

"My driver is waiting," Grace said, too quickly.

He inclined his head. "Of course."

Outside, the Peninsula's damp heat rushed back, lifting the scent of petrol, rain, and hotel flowers. The family car waited. The driver stepped forward.

Grace looked at the car, then at the city beyond it, and felt, with humiliating clarity, the exact shape of what she did not want. Not scandal. Not exposure. Return. Immediate, obedient return.

She heard herself say to the driver, "You can go."

The driver blinked. "Miss Grace?"

"I'll take a taxi."

The driver inclined his head and stepped back. Staff knew how to accept a deviation without appearing to witness it.

Luc's face changed by almost nothing.

Grace did not look at him. She turned and walked towards the city. The tram stop was not far — rails shining in the wet road, overhead wires humming faintly.

The bell sounded before the tram arrived.

Ding-ding.

Grace felt the sound move through her spine and settle somewhere behind the ribs.

The tram arrived with its old, stubborn slowness. She stepped on and climbed the narrow stairs. At the top she took the front seat by reflex. The tram smelled of varnished wood, damp fabric, and metal. Up here the air was warmer, less controlled. A handful of passengers sat scattered: an older man with a shopping bag, a young woman scrolling her phone, a couple holding hands without speaking. Nobody looked at Grace. Nobody cared.

The tram moved forward. Wet pavement, neon, buses, the whole bright exhausted organism sliding past.

At the next stop, someone climbed upstairs. A familiar scent — clean, not intrusive — reached her before she heard his voice.

"Ms Purvis," Luc said softly behind her. "I didn't want you getting home without knowing."

Grace did not turn at first. Turning would admit how much she had wanted to see him. She kept her eyes on the front window. "Knowing what."

"That I meant it," he said.

The tram bell chimed. Ding-ding. The city paused, obedient.

"You said I looked managed," Grace said finally.

"You do," Luc replied. "And you do it well."

"Do you think I don't know."

"I think you've been doing it so long you don't know what you feel until it's too late," he said, and the sentence was too intimate to be safe.

Grace's hands tightened on the edge of the seat. "And you," she said, because she needed to wound him back into being human. "You hide behind restraint and call it care."

His eyes flicked — a small hit. He did not deny it. He did not apologise. He simply sat with it, which was its own kind of honesty.

The tram bell chimed again. Ding-ding.

Grace turned her head. Their faces were close enough now that she could see the small details she had not allowed herself to notice. He did not look hungry. He looked deliberate.

"You can go," Grace said, and heard the lie in it.

Luc did not move. "If you want me to," he replied.

Grace stared at him and felt the cruel simplicity of it: choice. She reached back, fingers closing around his hand. The contact was warm, human, unhidden. The act startled her more than it startled him.

His thumb moved once over her knuckles. Not correction. Acknowledgement.

The tram continued forward. The city slid by. The bell chimed, patient and persistent.

Luc leaned in and kissed her.

It was not hungry. It was not frantic. It was deliberate. He had decided this was the one thing he would allow himself to do without editing. Grace felt the shock of it move through her body — heat, relief, fear — like a tide coming in too fast. She kissed him back, and the kiss felt like ignition, like a door opening she had not known she had been holding shut.

She pulled away first, not because she wanted to stop, but because she needed to breathe. She pressed her forehead lightly to his for a heartbeat, then sat back in the front seat.

Luc stayed close but did not reach for her again. His restraint returned, and this time it felt like respect rather than distance.

The tram slowed. Grace said abruptly, "My driver isn't waiting."

Luc nodded. "No."

The absurdity of the answer almost made her smile.

At the next stop he stood.

"I should go," he said.

Grace looked up at him. "Yes."

He moved down the stairs with the same quiet competence he used in every room.

The tram moved forward again. Ding-ding. Grace sat very still in the front seat, heart hammering, the wet road sliding under the window. The kiss had not solved anything. It had only made the existing world more difficult to survive honestly.

At home, her mother was waiting in the sitting room, phone in hand, as though she had been there all along. She looked up when Grace entered, eyes moving across her face once, quickly.

"You went," her mother said.

Grace nodded.

"Good," her mother said. "Did you behave?"

Grace's mouth went dry. "Yes," she lied.

Her mother nodded, satisfied, and returned to her phone. "Tomorrow. Hospital. Then we'll see."

Grace went upstairs and closed her door. Her hands shook slightly as she pulled out her phone. She found Theresa's name and typed: Need to talk. Not tonight. Tomorrow. She sent it before she could make it smaller.

Theresa replied within the minute: Come at eight. I'll have coffee.

No questions. Just a time and a place. It was enough.

Her phone buzzed again. Unknown number.

Hong Kong is smaller than you think.

Grace stared at the words until they blurred.

A second message arrived, same number.

Goodnight, Ms Purvis.

Grace sat very still, the air-conditioning hum loud in the silence, and realised she had been seen again.

## CHAPTER IX — AFTER IGNITION

Grace woke with the taste of champagne and tram air still at the back of her throat and the certainty of having been seen sitting in her chest like a held breath.

For a moment she lay still, unsure whether the thudding in her chest belonged to memory or alarm. Then the room reassembled itself: pale ceiling, controlled air, the faint hum of the house already working, porcelain touching porcelain somewhere below. The city had resumed. The house had resumed. Only her body lagged behind, still carrying the night as if it had lodged itself in muscle rather than in time.

She turned her head and saw the phone where she had left it in her bag on the chair. Even after a tram, a kiss, and two messages that made ordinary sleep feel absurd, some part of her had still obeyed the old instruction: keep it away.

She crossed the room, unzipped the bag, and pulled the phone out.

Hong Kong is smaller than you think.

Goodnight, Ms Purvis.

They looked different in morning light — less like danger, more like fact. That was worse. Facts did not flare and vanish. They sat where you had left them and waited for your body to catch up.

Grace opened the thread, stared at it, then locked the screen without typing. Replying would turn the night into continuation. Not replying did not make it disappear. It only bought her a few more hours in which to pretend the shape of the thing had not yet been decided.

She dressed carefully — plain clothes, nothing that could be described as attention-seeking. She left the pen in the drawer.

Downstairs, breakfast had been set. Toast, fruit, tea placed where her hand would fall. Grace sat and ate because her body was still a body even when her mind wanted to punish it for wanting more than one thing at once.

Her mother was already at the table, paper open, phone face down beside her plate. She wore grey silk, hair pulled back, the composure of a woman who had been awake for hours and saw no reason to mention it.

She looked at Grace's plate, then at Grace.

"You're eating."

Grace nodded.

Her mother poured herself tea. "We go to the hospital at ten."

Grace's stomach tightened. "Why not now."

"Because the consultant will be there at ten. And because you need to look steady."

"I am steady."

Her mother's eyes lifted. "You were out."

"I came back."

"That is not what I said." Her voice stayed gentle, which made it worse. "Grace."

The name was a hand on her wrist again.

Her mother took a sip of tea. "And you will not carry your phone openly today."

"Why."

"Because people talk. And because Catherine is being kind. We don't repay kindness with complications."

Grace heard: don't embarrass us.

"I didn't do anything," she said.

Her mother held her gaze for a beat. "Good," she replied, and the word sounded like approval for a child not touching a hot stove. "Then it will remain nothing."

The sentence was obscene in its calmness. Reality was optional as long as nobody spoke it aloud.

Her phone buzzed faintly inside the bag at her feet. Her body tensed. Her mother did not look at the bag. She did not have to.

"Later," she murmured, and the word managed to sound like permission and prohibition at once.

Her mother's screen lit. Grace caught the name before it was tilted away: Catherine.

"Catherine says to tell you she's thinking of you," her mother said. "People were relieved to see you last night."

Relieved. The word settled in her chest like a stone.

At ten, the car arrived. They crossed the city under low sky. At an intersection a tram crossed ahead of them and the bell reached the car too faintly to count as sound and too clearly not to. Grace kept her face towards the window.

The hospital corridor received them in its chilled hush. The nurse greeted her mother first. The consultant used the same careful face and the same careful language. Numbers steady. No acute deterioration. Continue as before.

Grace watched her mother translate possibility into certainty with the same ease she had used to translate Catherine's kindness into obligation. When the consultant left, her mother turned to Grace with a soft smile. "See," she said. "Stable."

Inside the room, her father looked the same and different. The machines hummed. His chest rose and fell. His hand was warm. Grace took it and felt the warmth as both comfort and cruelty.

Her father remained what he had been the day before: warm, breathing, absent.

"I want to come in alone later," she said once the door had closed.

Her mother turned her head. "Alone."

"Yes."

Her mother chose the family version of refusal. "We'll see," she said. "If the room is quiet. If he's resting. If the staff think it's appropriate."

If, if, if. Every private wish turned into a corridor of conditions before it could move.

Grace did not argue. She only looked back at the bed. She wanted to tell her father that she had kissed a man on a tram and did not know whether that made the world larger or smaller. She wanted to tell him that his line about her mother loving like a system had come back so hard it felt less like memory than instruction. She wanted him to open his eyes and say her name the way he used to, with the sense that names could briefly restore proportion.

Instead she said, very quietly, "I'm here."

The machine continued speaking in its little obedient sounds.

Outside the room, Theresa was waiting near the lift with coffee she had no intention of finishing. Her face changed by almost nothing when she saw Grace.

"You look terrible," Theresa said quietly.

Grace smiled in spite of herself. "Thank you."

"That was kindness."

"I know."

Theresa held out the coffee and Grace took it. They stood for a moment in the expensive hush with the lift doors closed and the lavender trying too hard.

"I meant what I said," Theresa murmured. "If you need to leave the house, leave."

Grace looked down at the coffee lid. "I did."

Theresa's eyes lifted. A question appeared and was disciplined away.

"Did it help."

Grace thought of the tram bell, the front seat, Luc's thumb once over her knuckles, the kiss, the texts, the house waiting when she got back as if it had not noticed the subtraction.

"No," she said. "But I went."

Theresa's mouth altered by the smallest degree — not approval exactly, but recognition.

"That may be the same thing for now."

Lunch with an aunt followed because lunches always followed. Soft shock, admiration, a gentle insistence on strength. Grace smiled until her face felt stiff. Her phone buzzed in her bag and she did not look. Her mother noticed that she did not look. That, perhaps, pleased her. Or perhaps it simply saved her the effort of intervening.

Back at the house, her mother went to her study. Grace went upstairs, shut her door, and took out the phone.

No new message from Luc.

The silence was its own pressure. He had given her two lines and then stopped. It could be respect. It could be the same restraint she had noticed in every room he entered,

now extended into absence. She had not realised how quickly she had begun listening for him until the listening met nothing and had to admit what it was.

She typed a reply and deleted it. Typed again and deleted it again. She did not know what she was refusing: him, herself, the possibility of a sequence she would not be able to survive honestly.

She typed:

I'm not sure what happens now.

Deleted it.

Then:

Why.

She looked at the single word for a long moment and could not tell whether it was too much or too little. Why did you follow. Why did you kiss me. Why did you let the lie stand. Why did you call me Ms Purvis as if that title could still contain anything after the tram.

She deleted that as well.

A message from Catherine sat in her inbox, warm and cheerful.

Darling, just a reminder that Deborah means well but is apt to carry things. Keep all future interactions light and avoid unnecessary specificity. Love.

Carry things. The phrase chilled her more than if Catherine had named scandal outright. Carrying was how this city

moved its truths: not loudly, not with malice, only efficiently.

Grace put the phone down and lay back without undressing.

She felt the kiss on her mouth again as if her body refused to let it become memory. She felt both powerful and ashamed.

She lay still and listened to the house continue around her — a door opening softly, then closing; the low movement of air through the vent; one footstep in the corridor and then none.

The kiss had not taken her out of the city's arrangements. It had only made them harder to misunderstand.

## CHAPTER X — CROSSING

By four o'clock, Grace had already lived three days' worth of other people's time.

The morning had begun in the private ward with the same careful nouns. No dramatic change. Continue monitoring. Wait. The consultant had spoken with the precise caution of a man who knew families heard hope wherever they wanted it. Grace watched her mother reshape each qualification into something the family could use, and by the time they left the hospital for lunch with an aunt who called her strong twice before coffee, the day already felt used up.

On the drive home her phone vibrated once in her bag. She did not look. Her mother noticed that she did not look, and said nothing.

At home the house resumed its expensive near-silence. Her mother disappeared into the study. Grace went upstairs, shut the door, and sat on the edge of the bed without taking off her shoes.

When Luc's message arrived, it did not pretend to be anything except itself.

If you want to see me, four o'clock. Peninsula.

No greeting. No apology. No softness. One line, like a door left open.

Grace read it three times. She looked, without quite deciding to, at the bedside drawer. The pen was inside. She kept her hand on the drawer pull for a moment, then let go.

She changed into a pale blouse and dark trousers because anything else would have felt theatrical. In the mirror she wiped off lipstick she had put on without thinking, irritated by how quickly she could imagine someone saying, softly, she's trying to look pretty at a time like this. Down the corridor a floorboard gave once under someone's careful step. The house was listening, as it always listened, without needing to ask a question.

She told the driver, "Peninsula," and nothing in his face altered. That was the danger of houses like this: the easiest lies were the ones that looked like routine.

The hotel received her in polish, flowers, and controlled air. Afternoon light lay across the lobby in expensive squares. Grace stood for a moment just inside the doors and felt the usual scan begin in her body — who was looking, who might carry a sentence.

Luc was seated off to one side, not in the bar proper but near enough to disappear into it. He had water in front of him, untouched. Dark suit, no tie, one cuff unfastened and folded back once as if the day had run longer than intended. When he stood, he did not smile as though they were meeting under simpler circumstances.

"Ms Purvis," he said, and the formality steadied her by making everything else feel less false.

"Mr Morel."

She sat opposite him. A waiter appeared, was dismissed with a glance, and disappeared. The room seemed to understand discretion as a kind of service.

They did not talk as they had talked in the bar three days ago. That conversation — managed, useful, face, the mother — had already been had. It did not need to be reopened. What remained was simpler and more dangerous: the fact of being here again, by choice, without Catherine's arrangement as alibi.

"How is he," Luc asked.

"The same."

He nodded once. He did not say he was sorry. He did not offer the word everyone else was using. The silence after the answer was its own kind of respect.

Grace looked at her hands. "I keep thinking I should be at the hospital."

"Should you."

"No." She heard the honesty of it and felt heat rise. "He doesn't know I'm there. He doesn't know I'm here. He doesn't know anything, and I keep sitting by that bed as if sitting were the same thing as helping."

Luc watched her without speaking. After a moment he said, "What would you do if nobody was watching."

The question caught like a struck match. Not because it was romantic. Because it was the one question the city never asked.

"I don't know," she said.

"Yes you do."

Grace looked at him then with an anger that was already too close to hunger. He was right. She did know. She had known since the tram. She had known since the bell and the front seat and his thumb moving once over her knuckles. The only thing she did not know was what kind of woman it would make her.

Luc stood first, unhurried. He did not reach for her hand. He did not dress the moment in language.

"I'm upstairs," he said. "You can come if you want."

That was all.

Grace sat alone at the table for almost a full minute. The lobby continued around her: a woman in linen turning pages at the bar, two men discussing something with the calm aggression of banking, a child in school uniform trailing a mother who never looked down. Ordinary life.

She stood. She crossed the lobby to the lifts with the calm of someone who belonged there. That was the most indecent part: nothing about her looked furtive. She looked like an adult moving from one polished interior to another. The hotel had already agreed not to be shocked.

The lift rose in silence.

His suite door was ajar. Warm light. Half-drawn curtains. The harbour flattened into glass and scattered light beyond the windows. A jacket on the back of one chair. A room already inhabited by a life that had existed before she entered it. Grace caught her own reflection in the darkened window — composed, steady, trained — and felt the absurd desire to ruin it.

Luc stood by the window with a glass of water. He turned when she came in. He did not cross the room. He simply waited.

Grace stepped over the threshold because she was tired of being the person who always left first.

She crossed the room first. He kissed her with deliberate restraint, and she hated how much she needed that restraint to break. She took hold of his tie and pulled him nearer, impatient with her own hesitation. His hands went to her waist, firm but unclaiming, and even then he kept leaving pauses in which she could stop. The pauses made things worse. They made the wanting hers.

She registered fragments and lost them again: the feel of his mouth at her throat, her own hand fisted in the sheet, his watch set square beside the hotel notepad, one of her blouse buttons under the chair by the window. When she went still for a second, he stopped at once.

"We stop here if you want."

The sentence was so plain it almost made her cry. Instead she kissed him again because kissing was easier than answering, and because wanting him did not cancel anything else. It only refused to wait for permission.

By the time the city had come fully alive in the glass, the sheet was twisted at her hip and the lamp was still on. She noticed stupid things because the body did that when the mind was trying not to think: the exact weight of his arm across her waist, the narrow strip of harbour light across the carpet, the sound of traffic far below like a city that had not paused to notice.

Afterwards, the quiet was too clean.

Her father arrived in her mind at once: his hand in the hospital bed, warm and absent; the muted monitor; the private ward keeping its tone level while other people decided what words could survive. Shame came with indecent speed. She turned her face away from Luc, furious at herself for how little time pleasure required to become consequence.

Luc did not fill the silence. After a while he said, very quietly, "I'm not asking you to make this into anything."

Grace let out a breath that might almost have been a laugh. "It already is something."

He accepted the sentence without trying to improve it. He stood, poured her water without asking, and set the glass

in her hand. The gesture was so ordinary it made her chest ache more than any tenderness would have.

"I have to go," she said.

"I know."

He did not ask her to stay. He did not ask when he would see her again. He did not offer a future tense that would have made the room feel cheaper.

In the lift down she steadied herself until by the time the doors opened on the lobby she looked calm enough to be invisible. The hotel had not altered. A florist was adjusting lilies. A couple argued softly over luggage.

The family car was waiting outside. Leather, hush, container.

At home, the lamps were on but the sitting room was quiet. Her mother was not waiting by the door. She was in the study, phone against her ear, speaking in the low administrative tone she used when the machine was running smoothly and did not require the visible hand. Grace stood in the hallway for a moment, listening to the even murmur of management through the closed door, and understood that her mother's absence from the sitting room was not an oversight. It was permission — the kind that could be revoked without ever having been named.

She went upstairs without being stopped. In her room she sat on the edge of the bed. The hotel soap remained on her

wrists. She held them to her face once, hating herself for it, then dropped her hands to her lap.

Her phone was already in her hand before she admitted she meant to use it. She found Theresa's name and typed:

I need you not to ask yet.

She sent it before she could make it smaller.

Theresa replied within seconds.

Whenever you're ready.

Three words. No questions. No diagnosis. No claim.

Grace put the phone down, turned off the light, and lay back without undressing. Her mouth still remembered the taste of a man who had said Ms Purvis in a way that meant she existed.

## CHAPTER XI — CHIPPED MUG

Grace did not wake with regret. She woke with logistics.

Her body still remembered heat; her mind already remembered corridors. By ten thirty she had showered, dressed, gone to the ward, and heard stable again. Her mother received each hedge with grave attention and translated it, by the lift, into something livable. On the drive back she opened her phone and said, "Your aunt at one. Then home. Catherine wants a follow-up call."

"I need to be out for an hour," Grace said.

Her mother's eyes lifted. "For what."

"Air."

"We have a terrace."

"I want to go alone."

A pause. Calculation. Then the version that could be lived with. "Where."

"Central," Grace said. "Just Central."

Her mother held her gaze for a beat, then nodded. "One hour. Back for lunch." Then, softly, offering kindness in the same breath as instruction: "No drama."

At the house Grace told the driver, "No car. Taxi." He hesitated — one beat, enough to hear the unasked word — then stepped back. In this house everybody's main skill was making the inevitable look like a decision.

Central was wetter and louder than the Peak, the surfaces older, the air less curated. Grace walked without destination for several minutes simply to feel her own feet on pavement and the absence of somebody else's itinerary. She stopped at a café that did not look as if it belonged to a hotel, ordered tea without a tray or linen, and sat by the window with her phone face down on the table.

When Luc's message arrived, she did not open it at once. She let herself sit with the small power of not responding. Then she turned the phone over.

If you can be out, come here. No staff. No Catherine. Just you. Forty minutes.

A coordinate pin sat beneath the message.

He had done it again: offered something that was also an arrangement. Yet it was not her mother's arrangement. It did not feel like a leash. It felt like a room with the lights off.

Grace checked her watch. One hour. Her mother's rule. Forty minutes. His.

She left money on the table and walked out.

The pin led her to an older office building near Connaught Road. Security desk. Turnstile. A guard who glanced at her and then away. Her phone buzzed once more.

Up.

The lift was fluorescent, mirrored, indifferent. The doors opened on a quiet floor, carpet swallowing sound. No sign,

no branding. A corridor and a door with frosted glass. She knocked. Luc opened almost at once.

No suit jacket. Shirtsleeves, collar open. The absence of armour should have felt intimate. It felt real.

Inside, the room was not luxurious. It was simply a working room: desk with papers in usable piles, laptop open, books that looked handled rather than purchased by the metre, a kettle on the side counter. The window gave onto the back of another building where laundry hung on metal rails in the damp light. No harbour. No skyline. No view to perform. On the desk sat two mugs. One was chipped at the rim.

Grace looked at the chipped mug and felt something loosen. It would not have survived a day in her mother's kitchen. Here it sat without apology.

"Tea?" Luc asked.

The question almost made her laugh. Tea was what staff brought when they wanted you to behave. Tea was what her mother offered when she wanted to turn feeling into ritual. Here, beside a kettle and a damaged mug, tea felt like a choice.

"Yes," Grace said.

He filled the kettle, turned it on, then sat opposite her and left the silence alone. It was the first time that day someone had sat with her without rearranging her into a story.

"You didn't have to come," he said.

"No."

"But you did."

"Yes."

The kettle built its low mechanical sound.

"Why here," she said. "Why not the Peninsula."

Luc looked towards the back window. "Because nothing in this room pretends to be better than it is."

Grace let the sentence sit. Plain enough to be almost rude. Exact enough not to need polishing.

"Nobody pretends in hospitals," she said, and knew it was false before it finished.

"They pretend with language," Luc replied. "It keeps families calm."

The kettle clicked off. He rose, passed her the chipped mug. The rim caught lightly against her lip. Absurdly grounding.

For a moment neither of them spoke.

"Tell me about you," she said abruptly, and heard how it sounded.

Luc's mouth moved once, almost a smile. "No," he said. "Tell me about your father."

"The doctors say stable," she said.

He waited, allowing the difference between the word and its speaker.

"I don't know what it means any more."

"It means the system can keep going without changing language."

The sentence was cruel in its clarity. She almost wished he had lied.

"And your mother?" he asked.

Grace's jaw tightened. "My mother is efficient."

Luc did not smile. "Efficiency can be love."

He said it carefully — not as consolation, not as defence.

"She's kind," Grace said, and felt the contradiction tighten in her throat. "And she's suffocating."

Luc nodded once. No surprise. No appetite for simplification.

"And you are very good at coping," he said.

Grace laughed once, quick and sharp. "I'm trained."

"Yes."

Calm. Accurate. Not comforting.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket. She ignored it. Luc's eyes moved towards the sound and back.

"Time," he said.

"One hour."

"Then forty minutes was ambitious."

"I can stay longer."

"You shouldn't."

The sentence landed wrong. It landed like her mother's voice.

"Don't do that," Grace said.

"Do what."

"Decide for me." Heat rose in her face. "I have enough people deciding for me."

Luc did not apologise. He did not charm the edge away. "I'm not deciding," he said, very still. "I'm seeing consequences you're pretending don't exist."

The bluntness hurt because it was exact.

"If you stay longer, you'll be late," he said. "Then you'll lie. Lies don't stay neutral here."

She hated him for being right.

"And you," she said, because she needed to wound him back into being human. "You speak as if you're not in it. But you are. You just wear it better."

Luc held her gaze. "Yes," he said. After a beat: "I'm in it."

He leaned back slightly, as if distance were what made truth survivable, then turned the chipped mug once between his hands.

"I've been living out of a suitcase since I was seventeen. People think that's freedom."

He set the mug down.

"It's also avoidance."

Grace said nothing. She did not want him to become tragic. Yet the honesty altered something in the air.

"Here I'm nobody's son," he said. "Here I'm also everyone's tool."

Tool. Useful. Same city, different grammar.

"What do you want here," Grace asked, and meant: in Hong Kong, in your life, in this.

Luc answered without dressing it up. "I want to stop moving." He held her gaze. "I want roots. A desk. A place I don't check out of."

It was so unromantic it felt intimate.

"And your bank will let you," Grace said, half-mocking, because the only way to touch sincerity without damaging yourself was often to nick it first.

"If I'm useful." Then, after the smallest pause: "And if I'm not inconvenient."

The word went deep. Not because her mother used it. Because she didn't. Because she never had to.

Grace looked towards the back window. Laundry shifted once in the damp light and settled. Somebody else's ordinary continuity, hanging between buildings as if it were still available in the world.

Her phone buzzed again. She took it out this time. One message from her mother.

Where are you.

No accusation. Worse: a requirement disguised as punctuation.

She typed: On my way.

Luc said nothing. He did not look at the screen. He did not rescue her from the fact of it.

"I have to go," Grace said.

He let her go without making it harder. At the door he said, quietly, "Ms Purvis."

Grace looked up.

"Be careful."

Not of him. Not with him. Of the rooms waiting outside.

The lift doors closed. Grace watched her own face in the mirror and tried, by increments, to rearrange it into something acceptable. Jaw first. Then eyes. Then the set of her shoulders. The building descended anyway.

The taxi took her back into her mother's orbit. Central loosened into Mid-Levels, then tightened again into the approach to the house. By the time the gate opened she looked steady enough to be believed.

Her mother was in the sitting room, phone in hand, as if she had not moved since the hour began. Her eyes went to Grace's face once, quickly, then to the clock.

"Good," her mother said.

## CHAPTER XII — BY DEGREES

Reputation never arrived as punishment. It arrived as warmth cooled by half a degree.

Grace noticed it first in the smallest places, which was how Hong Kong did its cruellest work. Not through confrontation, not through scenes, but through micro-changes that could always be denied. A greeting held a fraction shorter. A smile that did not quite reach the eyes. A message that arrived later than it used to. An invitation phrased as concern rather than request. All of it plausible. All of it shaping.

The morning after Luc's office, Grace woke with the word inconvenient lodged like a splinter. She had not expected to feel steadier. She had not expected to feel more exposed. The room with the chipped mug and the laundry at the back window had not offered escape. It had offered accuracy, and accuracy was a kind of danger in a family that survived by selecting which truths were allowed to exist.

At the house, a staff member approached her in the hallway with a cream envelope held on both palms, as if delicacy required choreography. "Miss Grace," she said softly. "Mrs Purvis asked me to give you this."

Inside was thick note-card paper, tasteful enough to pass for intimacy. Catherine's hand was neat and certain.